

Customer Complaint Handling — Store Floor Standard

Company: Meridian Retail Co. | Doc ID: RET-CX-008 | Version: 3.0 | Effective: 2026-02-15 | Owner: Customer Experience

Purpose & scope

All floor associates and shift leads at Meridian Retail locations must follow this standard when a customer expresses dissatisfaction about product quality, pricing, wait time, or staff interaction. Applies in-aisle, at checkout, and at the service desk.

Key terms

LEARN model: Listen, Empathize, Apologize, Resolve, Notify (manager if needed).

Service recovery: Action that fixes the immediate problem (exchange, refund per policy, rain check).

Moment of truth: First 30 seconds of the complaint — sets tone for entire interaction.

Standard procedure

1. Stop what you are doing; face the customer; remove earbuds or radio chatter.
2. Listen without interrupting until the customer finishes their first statement.
3. Empathize with a specific phrase — not "I'm sorry you feel that way" alone.
4. Apologize for the experience (not necessarily admitting company fault).
5. Resolve: offer one clear next step within your authority (\$25 exchange without receipt per policy).
6. Notify shift lead if customer requests manager, mentions legal action, or transaction exceeds \$100.

Approved phrases

"Thank you for telling me — I want to make this right before you leave the store."
"That shouldn't have happened. Let me pull up your receipt and see the fastest fix."
"I can exchange this today or give you store credit — whichever works better for you."
"I'm going to get my shift lead so we can authorize that refund on the spot."

Scenarios

Scenario A — Wrong size, no receipt: Customer bought jeans last week, tag removed. Associate checks SKU on floor, verifies style still sold, offers exchange or store credit per 14-day policy.

Scenario B — Long checkout line: Customer yells that only one register is open. Associate acknowledges wait, calls for backup on radio, offers to hold items if customer needs to browse.

Scenario C — Damaged product: Box crushed on shelf. Associate inspects item, offers replacement from stock or 10% courtesy discount if last unit.

Escalation matrix

Trigger	Escalate to
Request for manager	Shift lead within 3 minutes
Threat of social media / BBB	Shift lead + log in CX portal same day
Suspected fraud (duplicate receipts)	Loss prevention — do not accuse customer
Injury in store	Manager + incident form IR-002

Do / Don't

Do: Lower your volume if customer is loud; use customer's name from loyalty app if available.

Don't: Blame another associate by name; say "That's policy" without offering an alternative; walk away mid-conversation.